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# A State of Controlled Chaos

THE SITUATION in Punjab in early 1983 can be summed up as follows: the moderate Akali Dal leadership was demoralized by their repeated failure to get any face-saving concessions from the Central government that would enable them to withdraw their morcha. In the face of Bhindranwale's criticism, they had to keep increasing the level of their demands. Bhindranwale's profile was on the ascendant, and he continued to carry on with his unbridled acts of extremism to instil fear in the minds of the Hindus of Punjab, which had an impact on Haryana too. The Punjab government was frustrated, as they were left with very little initiative to take on-the-spot independent decisions. A dispirited Punjab Police and the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) were accusing each other of being communal in the discharge of their duties. It was a recipe for disaster.

The national elections were still two years away. Therefore, the main challenge for the 1 Akbar Road group at that time was to ensure that the pressure caused by the continued insecurity and chaos did not cross the threshold that would force them to make a premature intervention before the end of 1984. This was not an easy task. To ensure this, a three-member informal think-tank comprising senior officers Cabinet Secretary C.R. Krishnaswami Rao Sahib, Principal Secretary to the PM P.C. Alexander and Home Secretary T.N. Chaturvedi (succeeded later by M.M.K. Wali) was created to micro-manage the affairs of Punjab.

Unfortunately, they had little experience of Punjab. Perhaps their ignorance was considered a plus point by Indira Gandhi, as they had